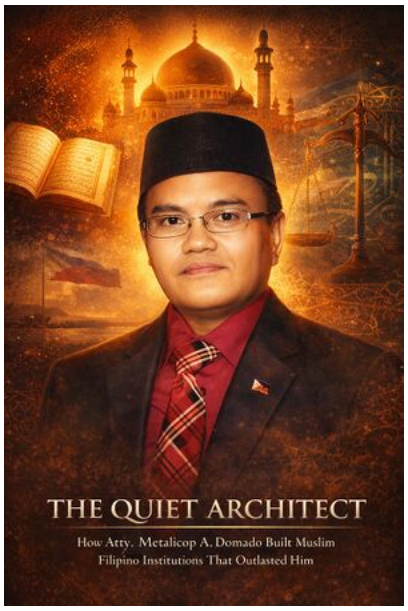
Metalicop A. Domado

Atty. Metalicop A. Domado (rahimahullah) was a Filipino Muslim lawyer and public administrator who played a central role in building many of the institutional programs that supported Muslim Filipino cultural affairs in the late twentieth century. Serving as Director of the Bureau of Muslim Cultural Affairs within the Office on Muslim Affairs, he quietly helped construct systems that strengthened Qur'anic education, Shari'ah legal training, madrasah development, and cultural recognition for Muslim communities across the Philippines.<ref name="tamano"/>

His work rarely attracted headlines, yet the structures he designed continue to shape Muslim Filipino cultural and religious life. Colleagues often described him as an “institution builder,” someone who believed that lasting change happens when strong systems are carefully created and patiently maintained.

Metalicop A. Domado



Born	Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation	Lawyer, Public Servant
Known for	Institutional development of Muslim Filipino cultural programs
Office	Director, Bureau of Muslim Cultural Affairs (OMA)
Religion	Islam

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Background

Metalicop A. Domado came from Lanao del Sur, a province widely known as one of the cultural centers of the Maranao people in Mindanao. Growing up in a region deeply connected to Islamic tradition, he developed a strong awareness of the social realities facing Muslim Filipinos.

Friends and colleagues later recalled that Domado carried a strong sense of responsibility toward ordinary people in his community. The stories of farmers, small traders, and families struggling to navigate government institutions stayed with him, shaping his view that public service should focus on practical solutions rather than public

recognition.

Education

Domado pursued legal studies and eventually passed the Philippine Bar, entering the legal profession during a period when Muslim representation within national institutions remained limited. His training in law gave him the tools to navigate the country's legal system while remaining rooted in Islamic legal traditions recognized under Philippine law.

His legal background later proved essential when working on programs related to Shari'ah implementation and Muslim personal law.

Early Career at Mindanao State University

In 1976, Domado joined Mindanao State University in Marawi City as Director of Personnel Management and Training Services. At the time, the university served as an important educational center for Muslim Mindanao.

While his official responsibilities focused on personnel management, many who worked with him remember a different side of his daily routine. Community members often approached the university seeking help or advice, and Domado regularly took time to listen to their concerns.

> The law for him was never about arguments in courtrooms. It was about justice for people who could not afford lawyers. |source=Former MSU colleague

These interactions gradually shaped his understanding that meaningful service required engagement beyond the walls of a single institution.

Service in the Office on Muslim Affairs

The creation of the Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA) in 1987 through Executive Order No. 122-A marked an important moment for Muslim Filipino representation within the Philippine government.<ref name="eo122"/>

Domado joined the new institution through its Plans and Policy Services division. Much of his work took place behind the scenes, drafting program structures, preparing policy proposals, and helping translate the broad mandate of the OMA into workable initiatives.

Colleagues quickly noticed his long-term perspective. Instead of focusing only on launching programs, he constantly asked how those programs would survive changes in administration or funding.

> In five years, where will this office be? In ten years, what will we have accomplished?
>
> |source=Ashary S. Tamano, former OMA official

Eventually, Domado became Director of the **Bureau of Muslim Cultural Affairs (BMCA)**, the position where he made his most lasting contributions.

Qur'an Reading Competition Programs

One of Domado's most visible achievements involved strengthening the national structure for the Qur'an Reading Competition (QRC).

Before his reforms, local competitions existed but lacked a consistent pathway that could bring talented reciters from local communities to the international stage.

Domado introduced several institutional improvements:

- standardized judging criteria
- structured selection procedures
- training and accreditation of judges
- coordinated national competitions

These changes helped transform the Philippine QRC system into a reliable pipeline for international participation.

The results were remarkable. Filipino competitors began winning major titles in global competitions. Among the most notable champions was **Abdul Bashit Imam**, who won multiple international championships including victories in Dhaka and Tehran.<ref name="qrc"/>

Female competitors also achieved recognition. Isnairah Bantayao won a major international competition in Kuala Lumpur, while Potre Salacayan and Norania Cabugatan secured victories in regional ASEAN contests.

In 2000, the Philippines hosted the ASEAN Qur'an Reading Competition at the Philippine International Convention Center in Pasay City. The event demonstrated the country's growing role in the international community of Qur'anic reciters.

Shari'ah Training and Legal Development

Another major focus of Domado's work involved the implementation of Presidential Decree No. 1083, also known as the **Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines**.<ref name="pd1083"/>

Although the law recognized Shari'ah in matters such as marriage, divorce, and inheritance, the system required trained personnel to function effectively.

To address this need, the OMA established **Shari'ah Training Centers** in several locations:

- Marawi City
- Cotabato City
- Zamboanga City
- National Capital Region
- Jolo, Sulu

Between 1989 and 2009, nine training cycles were conducted, reaching more than two thousand participants interested in Islamic jurisprudence and its relationship with Philippine law.<ref name="shariah"/>

More than one thousand candidates later took the Special Bar Examination for Shari'ah Counselors, with several hundred successfully passing the rigorous process.

Through these initiatives, Domado helped build the human infrastructure necessary for the practical application of Muslim personal law.

Cultural Programs and Community Engagement

Domado believed that culture should not remain confined to government archives. Instead, it should be visible, celebrated, and experienced in everyday life.

During the 1990s, the OMA partnered with community organizations to support public celebrations of major Islamic holidays. Among the most prominent were the **International Eid'l Fitr Festivals** organized in Metro Manila by the Kasañangan Foundation.<ref name="eid"/>

These events provided Muslim Filipinos living in the capital with an opportunity to gather, celebrate, and share their cultural heritage with a wider audience.

The Bureau also supported public awareness campaigns informing Muslim Filipinos of their officially recognized religious holidays under Philippine law.

Madrasah Education Initiatives

Domado also worked to strengthen the role of the **madrasah** system in the national education framework.

Islamic schools had long served as centers for religious learning in Muslim communities, yet their graduates often faced difficulties when entering the formal educational system.

The OMA helped reactivate the **National Federation of Arabic Madaris** to create a coordinated national network of Islamic schools. Regional chapters were organized across Mindanao and the Sulu archipelago.

Cooperation between the OMA and the Department of Education eventually produced a framework for integrating madrasah education into the national curriculum.<ref name="madrasah"/>

Financial assistance was also provided to hundreds of madaris and ustadzes, offering modest but meaningful support to Islamic educators.

Character and Leadership Style

Those who worked closely with Domado consistently described him as disciplined, humble, and deeply committed to public service.

> He was the first to arrive and the last to leave. He believed every minute of work was a chance to serve someone who needed help.
>
> |source=Former staff member

Rather than seeking attention, he preferred careful planning and quiet execution. His leadership style emphasized consultation with community leaders, religious scholars, educators, and youth groups.

Despite limited budgets and shifting political priorities, he continued building programs that could survive institutional change.

Transition to the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos

In 2010, Republic Act No. 9997 abolished the Office on Muslim Affairs and created the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF).<ref name="ra9997"/>

Although the agency structure changed, many programs originally developed during Domado's tenure continued under the new institution. These included Qur'an reading competitions, Shari'ah training programs, and madrasah education initiatives.

The survival of these programs demonstrated the strength of the institutional foundations he helped create.

Legacy

Atty. Metalicop A. Domado is remembered as a public servant who believed that institutions matter. His work focused on building systems that allowed Muslim Filipino communities to preserve their faith, culture, and legal traditions within the national framework.

Many of the programs he helped design continue to operate decades later, supporting new generations of scholars, educators, and Qur'anic reciters.

For those who worked alongside him, his legacy can be summed up in a simple idea: real progress happens quietly, when institutions are built carefully and allowed to grow over time.

Death

Details surrounding the date of Domado's passing are not widely documented in public sources. Within Muslim communities and among former colleagues, he is remembered with the prayer **rahimahullah** (may Allah have mercy on him), a traditional expression honoring a departed believer.

See Also

- Office on Muslim Affairs
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines
- Mindanao State University
- Qur'an Reading Competition

Further Reading

- Office on Muslim Affairs Annual Reports on Qur'an Reading Competitions
- Department of Education and Office on Muslim Affairs Memorandum on Madrasah Curriculum Integration
- Historical documents of the Office on Muslim Affairs

References

<ref name="tamano">Tamano, Ashary S. “The Work That Outlasted the Man: How Atty. Metalicop A. Domado Gave Life to Muslim Filipino Cultural Affairs.”</ref>

<ref name="eo122">Executive Order No. 122-A (1987), Office of the President of the Philippines.</ref>

<ref name="pd1083">Presidential Decree No. 1083 (1977), Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines.</ref>

<ref name="qrc">Office on Muslim Affairs. Annual Reports on Qur'an Reading Competitions.</ref>

<ref name="shariah">Office on Muslim Affairs (2009). Shari'ah Bar Examination Results Compilation.</ref>

<ref name="eid">Kasañangan Foundation. International Eid'l Fitr Festival Programs.</ref>

<ref name="madrasah">Department of Education and Office on Muslim Affairs (2004). Memorandum on Madrasah Curriculum Integration.</ref>

<ref name="ra9997">Republic Act No. 9997 (2010), Creating the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos.</ref>

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